Supporting Emeritus Scientists in Research

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Emeritus professors make substantial contributions to science—continuing research, refereeing manuscripts, mentoring early-career colleagues, and advising institutions—often at negligible cost to their institutions. Yet support varies widely internationally, from active emeritus programmes at ETH Zürich and Leiden to largely honorary status with minimal infrastructure in France, Italy, and Spain.

The evidence does not support assumptions of inevitable decline at retirement age. Nearly 40% of U.S.-trained doctoral scientists aged 71–75 remain actively employed. While individual productivity varies, the question is whether systems enable those wishing to contribute to do so.

The concern about competition with early-career scientists is valid, but reflects a zero-sum view of research funding. Emeriti typically require different support—bringing collaborative funding, contributing to ongoing projects, and taking on reviewing and administrative work that burdens mid-career colleagues.

We propose four practical steps. First, institutions should provide basic infrastructure: institutional affiliation, email, library access, and where feasible, workspace. Second, international mobility should be encouraged through retired scientist exchange programmes between countries. Third, funding bodies should adopt age-blind grant eligibility, assessed on merit alone. Fourth, modest emeritus-specific funding should support collaborative projects pairing senior expertise with junior innovation.

The financial case is straightforward: supporting 1,000 emeritus professors with €10,000 each would cost €10 million annually—negligible compared to Horizon Europe's €93.5 billion budget. More importantly, science is conducted by people. The knowledge, judgment, and connections accumulated over long careers do not expire when employment ends. A research system that discards these resources due to age is not being efficient—it is being wasteful.

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